inhibitions, and firmly established on the principles of sovereignty.'

Indira reminded Ershad that before Bangladesh could be free, the blood of Indian martyrs had cemented the country's foundation. Seldom in history have people had to pay so heavy a sacrifice for a goal.

Indira further said: 'We in India wish for our close friends what we want for ourselves— political strength and economic ability to fulfil the expectations of the people. It is our policy to see you stable and strong. We try constantly and earnestly to cooperate with you.'

These statements gave voice to the apprehensions of both Indira and Ershad. They needed an aggressive diplomatic exercise to soothe nerves in both countries. In 1983, External Affairs Minister P.V. Narsimha Rao flew to Dhaka to attend a bilateral meeting.

A R&AW agent codenamed Yasin Mohammed told me that the agency was particularly worried over the increasing influence of the Jamaat-e-Islami after Ershad came to power. The Jamaat cadre was swelling and anti-India propaganda was gaining traction among fundamentalists.

Yasin said, 'The fear among us was that Jamaat could transform itself into a mainstream force and play a crucial role whenever elections were held in Bangladesh. Although Ershad was quick to foresee the hazard an outfit like Jamaat posed for the country, he maintained a measured silence on certain activities fearing that he would be branded as pro-India.'